

7.2 Opportunities and challenges of urbanisation

Urban living can provide many opportunities, economically, socially, and culturally (Table 7.3). With more people moving into cities, governments have to take active steps to better support residents. For example, facilities like hospitals, schools, and roads are built or improved. These facilities then improve residents' quality of life, such as their education and health, and provide employment opportunities. As more people move into towns and cities, governments, organisations, and businesses may invest more money into cultural events, and more leisure services may open.

Table 7.3: The opportunities of urban living

Housing	Cities often provide a greater variety of housing (quality and quantity); therefore, a range of different income groups can live within a city.
Economic development	More jobs, a centralised market, and faster trade lead to increased production and services in high-density urban areas. Cities are the focus of finance and retail.
Increased consumption	Generally higher individual wealth means people living and working in large towns and cities have more disposable income to spend on a wider choice of goods and services.
Employment	There are more jobs and a greater variety of jobs in urban areas. This means there are low-skilled and high-skilled jobs available in both the formal and informal economies.
Services	Generally, access to health and educational services are significantly better in cities. Hospitals are often more accessible. Large towns and cities often have better access to electricity, piped water, safe drinking water, and internet access. Transport facilities are highly developed and often receive funding for regular upgrades. It can be easier and faster to get from place to place in a city or town.
Leisure and entertainment	Most amenities and entertainment are easy to reach. Clubs, restaurants, and cinemas are more commonly found in cities. New attractions often open in a city before anywhere else.
Culture	Cities and towns tend to have more cultural and ethnic diversity, which is reflected in a greater mix of restaurants, cultural institutions, and entertainment venues. This helps build broader cultural appreciation and understanding.



Source A: Opportunities of urban living

TASK 1: Study Source A

- Source A shows four images of cities. In pairs, discuss the potential opportunities of urban living shown in the photographs. How could you classify these opportunities?
- Sometimes the opportunities of working and living in urban areas can cause 'conflicts' between different stakeholders (groups of people who work and/or live in cities). Explain two conflicts that may be associated with groups of people who work and live in cities.

Challenges and opportunities of rapid urban growth

The speed and scale of rapid urban growth brings many challenges. Some cities in MICs and LICs in particular struggle to keep up with the pace of urban growth. These challenges can be categorised into environmental, social, and economic challenges.

Environmental challenges

Every year, thousands of people die because of poor air quality in urban areas. One of the major sources of pollution is motor vehicles. Motor vehicles emit nitrous oxides, carbon monoxide, and sulphur dioxides. **Noise pollution** is also high in cities, with noise coming from traffic and construction. Road traffic noise has been associated with psychological stress, sleep disturbance, and heart disease. These problems tend to be worse in LICs. Cars and other vehicles in LICs,

for example, are often less fuel-efficient and produce more pollution because they are older, poorly serviced, and lack clean, environmentally friendly technology.

Water pollution is another major problem in many cities. The large number of people, vehicles, and industries often discharge pollutants into rivers.



Source **B**: Traffic congestion in Lagos, Nigeria



Source **C**: Pollution smog over Los Angeles, USA

Social and economic challenges

In many cities, particularly in LICs, providing residents with services such as healthcare, schools, waste collection, or street maintenance is a real challenge. This can lead to problems such as poor roads and a build-up of rubbish in the streets. For example, there is a huge rubbish tip in Phnom Penh, Cambodia called Dump Hill. Thousands of people live at the tip and make their living from collecting and selling other people's waste. This includes many children who then don't attend school. Some become seriously ill because of the unhealthy conditions of working and living in rubbish.

Within many cities there are huge **inequalities** between the rich and poor. The cost of land and housing combined with a shortage of supply means the quality of life between rich and poor can be stark. Issues, such as waste management and service provision, are often far worse for poor urban residents. In most HICS, poorer residents usually live in inner-city areas, edge-of-town estates, and high-rise flats. In LICs, poorer people often live in **informal settlements**. These are homes often self-built by families from materials that they can find, such as waste plastic sheets, cardboard boxes, and corrugated iron. About 60% of the urban population in African cities live in informal settlements. Many governments use their police or the army to demolish them from time to time. Other governments realise that shanty housing is a self-help way of addressing the housing shortage.



Figure 7.1: Garbage dump at Choeung Ek, Phnom Penh, Cambodia

TIP

Informal settlements are known by different names around the world. They are known as *favelas* in Brazil, *barriadas* elsewhere in Latin America, *bidonvilles* in North Africa, and *bustees* in India.

Although there are a greater number and range of jobs available in cities, finding appropriate work can still be a challenge due to competition and skills required for some jobs. **Unemployment** and **underemployment** are problems for many people. Consequently, cities in high- and low-income countries have many people working in the **informal sector** of the economy. These are activities that are outside the tax structures of a country. The informal economy includes both legal activities (for example, selling homemade food on the streets) and illegal activities (for example, begging).



Figure 7.2: Indian street vendors selling vegetables on the streets of Kathmandu, Nepal

TASK 2: Study Sources **B** **C**

- With reference to Sources B and C, explain one economic, one social, and one environmental problem created by traffic congestion in cities.
- Explain why urban inequalities often increase as cities rapidly grow.

- c Suggest two advantages and two disadvantages of working in the informal economy.
- d Many people move to urban areas in LICs for a better quality of life. Do you think all people achieve this? Give reasons for your answer.

Opportunities of rapid urban growth

Rapid urban growth leads to increased production and consumption in urban areas. This means a greater number and variety of urban opportunities. As more people live and work in urban areas, governments and town and city authorities need to invest in technological and infrastructural projects including housing, transportation, communication, education, and healthcare facilities. Urban areas become hubs of creation and investment which provide opportunities for further economic growth and technological development and social and cultural interaction. This can lead to the development of more inclusive, efficient, and innovative cities.

The impacts of urban sprawl

One of the consequences and challenges of urbanisation, particularly for large towns and cities in HICs, is **urban sprawl**. Urban sprawl is where the countryside is lost to the outward growth of large towns and cities around the world. The open land around the edge of a city is often in great demand for housing, industry, shopping, recreation, and public utilities such as reservoirs and sewage works. This area where the countryside meets the built-up part of towns and cities is known as the **rural-urban fringe**.



Source **D**: Cartoon depicting urban sprawl

As cities grow, much of the population shifts from the centre towards the suburbs (**suburbanisation**). Associated services and jobs also move to the suburbs. This causes significant land-use changes on the edge of urban areas. In HICs, there has been an increase in out-of-town retailing, with large superstores and shopping centres located near or on the rural-urban fringe. This takes trade away from the city centre, leading to a decline in customers and the closure of some shops and businesses in town and city centres. As the suburbs spread, adequate facilities like schools, shops, and health centres are needed to meet the demands of the growing population. This can have a positive impact on the rural population who benefit from these additional services, but long-term countryside residents sometimes complain about the loss of their rural way of life.

Urban sprawl has many environmental impacts. Environmentalists believe that new developments should be built on **brownfield sites** (land within the built-up urban area that has been abandoned and unused). However, facilities and services are often built on undeveloped **greenfield sites** on the rural-urban fringe because these have good accessibility and space for parking. This can destroy valuable habitats.

The expansion of urban areas also means more impermeable surfaces (for example, roads and car parks), which increases the flood risk in urban areas. More traffic congestion at the edge of towns and cities also increases air pollution, which can then cause respiratory and other health problems for residents.



Figure 7.3: Brownfield site



Figure 7.4: Greenfield site

TASK 3: Study Source D

- a** Define the term 'urban sprawl'
- b** Study the cartoon in Source D. What do you think the cartoon is suggesting about urban sprawl?
- c** Describe and explain one social, one economic, and one environmental impact of urban sprawl on the rural-urban fringe.

TASK 4

Building on greenfield sites is controversial. Prepare for a class debate about the advantages and disadvantages of building on greenfield and brownfield sites, with half the class being 'for' building on greenfield sites and the other half being 'against'.